

Metropolitan Police Academy



3.1 Basic Report Writing

Introduction

Completing a comprehensive and well-written report is an essential task for an MPD officer. It is how we document all information and facts to ensure all stakeholders have the required information for the criminal justice process. The bulk of an officer's report writing activity involves the documentation of incidents and crimes that involve the public. Many such reports form the basis for the successful criminal prosecution of suspects arrested for these crimes. They serve as the public's official record of events including the agency's response to those incidents. The courts, attorneys, private companies, the media, and the public can request and review MPD reports. Even with modern data entry technologies such as Mark43, it is still up to officers to compose a narrative that relates the facts of an incident in an organized and objective manner. It is critical that the facts of a reported incident are properly organized, with attention to detail.

3.1.1 Define a report, its functions, and value

A report is an account or statement describing an event or situation in detail. An incident report, also called an offense report, is MPD's official record of an event. Reports range from documentation of a minor loss or accident to documentation of a major criminal event. Most of an MPD officer's time will be utilized documenting incidents and crimes that involve the public. Some of these reports will become the foundations of criminal cases that are adjudicated in DC Superior Court.

Police reports may be used in a variety of ways. For example, they will often be used internally for administrative purposes. Such administrative reports document something as simple as a tree branch falling on a police cruiser or an officer losing his/her flashlight during a foot chase. These Damage to Property and Lost Property Reports (PD 43) are important official documents that chronicle events that occur at MPD. These reports justify agency action in response, such as the repair of a cruiser, the replacement of a flashlight, or other basic operational necessities that a police agency encounters. Police reports are also the basis for actions by police supervisors.

A well-written and thought-out report presents the facts explaining actions taken by police officers. How was a police flashlight lost? What was the underlying criminal matter that preceded a police officer's use of force? An accurate report is essential to the agency action required to account for such events. A supervisor will use the reports to deem whether further training, corrective action, or government expenditures are justified, so accuracy is vital.

Individuals outside of MPD also review agency reports. For example, attorneys and prosecutors review police reports on a daily basis. These reports help determine whether criminal or civil litigation will be pursued involving reported incidents. An accurate and well-written report can determine whether a high-profile criminal case leads to a successful prosecution. Alternatively, a poorly written police report can create unnecessary litigation either for the Department, DC government, or a private party. Reports make up the foundation of many cases at DC Superior Court and the US District Court for the District of Columbia. Reports may be scrutinized by the public or media, even prior to a formal court proceeding.

With the increasing scrutiny of police departments around the country by the press, police reports are constantly being requested to establish basic facts surrounding potentially controversial events. A properly written report can prevent misunderstandings and unneeded controversy in questionable incidents. There are basic steps to writing a good report.

3.1.2 Differentiate the basic steps of report writing

The first step to writing a good report is documenting the factual details of the incident/offense.

- Name/address/date of birth (DOB)/phone number/email of involved persons (witness and offender)
- Suspect description
- Relationships of involved persons to each other
- Type of call/problem/issue/classification
- Details of the incident, including **who, what, when, where, how, and why** (if known)
- Observations/perceptions
- Officer action taken including investigation and response/action of other personnel
- Injuries/medical treatment information
- Nature of property damage, if any
- Description of evidence/property seized/stolen/found

The next step is to properly evaluate this information and classify it according to DC laws and MPD directives. The officer must decide the best course of action to pursue according to laws and directives. The facts and circumstances obtained by the officer will allow a proper classification after the officer has evaluated the relevant information. Officer notes will become discoverable material in the prosecution of criminal cases.

After an MPD officer has determined the appropriate classification of an incident/offense, it is incumbent upon him/her to broadcast this information in certain instances. This can help other units canvass for suspects and recognize crime patterns. Once this has been done, actual report writing can take place.

3.1.3 Compose chronologically-structured narratives

The narrative is the section that most people are interested in reading. The narrative is the officer's documented account of who, what, when, where, how, and why. It should be clear, concise, and easy to understand.

The narrative must be written in chronological order. What initially happened must be written before the end result justifying an arrest is mentioned. What caused the incident to happen must be written before the end result. It is especially important for narratives in the Arrest Report (PD 163) to unfold the events in a manner that anyone who may not have been there can how an officer came to the final conclusion (arrest).

3.1.4 Discuss the Department's standard identifiers used in report writing

MPD has strict requirements in regards to the standard identifiers used in MPD reports. Uniformity of identifiers allows MPD reports to be read consistently and without confusion between terms.

The identifiers are as follows:

Complainant	C1, C2 or C3	A party who is a victim or who has a direct stake in the matter.
Victim	V1	A person who the crime was committed against
Suspect(Subject)	S1, S2, S3	A person who is believed to have committed a crime (not used in arrest narrative)
Witness	W1, W2, W3	A person who sees or hears an event or its aftermath.
Defendant	D1, D2, D3	An adult suspect who has been arrested for the commission of a crime. (used in the arrest narrative)
Respondent	R1, R2, R3	A juvenile who is arrested for the commission of a crime.
Reporting Person	RP1	A person making a report on behalf of another who is either unable or is not available to make the report
Missing Person	M1, M2	A person who is or was missing.
Vehicle	VEH 1	A vehicle.

A sample incident listed in a public narrative:

C1 reports that the listed damage to VEH1 occurred by unknown means.

A sample offense listed in a public narrative:

C1 reports that S1 smashed the passenger-side window of VEH1 and stole the listed items. A canvass produced no witnesses at this time.

NOTE: These reports address the basic questions of who, what, when, where, how, and why.

3.1.5 Assess the documents used for writing event reports

Standard types of MPD Reports include:

- **Initial Report:** This type of report documents all incidents or offenses when an MPD officer first responds. The public narrative must include information about each element of the crime. For example, “V-1 reports that S-1 entered the bedroom and struck her multiple times in the face with a fist...”
- **Internal Report:** This type of report is a supplemental report that records additional information relating to incidents or offenses in initial reports. This includes canvass results, additional eyewitness accounts, etc. Internal reports are also used to change the classification of the initial report, if need be. Supplemental reports are made directly to the original report on Mark43.
- **Arrest Report:** This type of report is used to document arrests and present information to a prosecutor in order to charge a suspect as an adult. It must establish probable cause. This may also be used to document arrests and present information to a prosecutor in order to charge a juvenile.
- **Traffic Crash Report:** This type of report documents certain vehicular collisions that occur in Washington, DC.
- **Property Record (PD 81):** All property that MPD takes possession of is recorded on this form. Examples include evidence, recovered stolen autos, found property, etc.

3.1.6 Demonstrate spelling and grammar in report writing

In order to have a report that is effective in presenting the facts surrounding an incident, the usage of correct spelling and grammar is imperative. A report lacking proper spelling and grammar lacks credibility. Common grammatical issues include.

Spelling

Below are some commonly misspelled words:

i before e except after c

- unless used as a, as in neighbor or weigh...
- except, of course, for the exceptions (seize, either, weird, height, foreign, leisure, conscience, counterfeit, forfeit, neither, science, species, sufficient)

Missing silent e (for example: quit – quite, bit – bite, cut – cute)

Changing y to i before a suffix (for example: family – families, dry – driest, fry – fried, happy – happily)

Double consonants (for example: dropped, blessed, flagging, dessert)

Plurals: s or es, or no change (for example: potato – potatoes, splash – splashes, bus – buses, police – police)

Homophones (words that sound alike) and commonly confused words (for example: two/to/too, their/there/they're, affect/effect, its/it's)

A lot - This is always written as two words.

Proper Capitalization

Make sure you have capitalized appropriately. You'll need a capital for:

- the beginning of a sentence
- proper nouns
- titles (of both people and written works)

Punctuation

Check your work for missing or incorrectly used punctuation. Here are some of the more common errors:

- comma misuse (this is the most common one)
- missing question mark at the end of a question
- missing period at the end of a sentence
- colon and semi-colon misuse
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Verb Tenses

The verb tenses within a sentence should be compatible. This is called parallelism. For example:

- George wants to go to a movie today, but I wanted to do something outdoors.
- The students were whispering to each other when the teacher spoke.

As well, you shouldn't unnecessarily switch verb tenses within the text.

- Once upon a time there was a little dog. The dog was black and brown, with some white stripes. The dog liked to walk in the park where he could chase other dogs.

Vocabulary and Word Choice

Use appropriate vocabulary with minimal police jargon.

Make sure you've used the right words to explain yourself. There are several different things to consider for vocabulary:

- **Vocabulary for audience**
Have you used clear, simple terminology so that most people will understand the text? Who is your intended audience? \ Does the terminology used give the most information possible??
- **Vocabulary for subject**
Have you used the vocabulary generally used to discuss your subject? If you've written a police report about a theft, have you actually used the words *suspect*, *stolen*, and *property*? If not, do you have a good reason for not doing so?

Sentence Structure

- use introductory words or phrases occasionally

- for emphasis, use a very short sentence beside a longer, more complex sentence
- use punctuation to help vary the sentence structure
- make sure the verb tenses in complex sentences are parallel
- verb tenses should be compatible
- verb forms should be similar (e.g. all ending with *ed*, or all ending with *ing*)
- in a list, articles (a, an, the) do not need to be repeated
- comparisons should be made in similar form (I *like* apple pie, and she prefers cherry. I *like* apple pie, and she likes cherry.)

Transitions

Do your sentences flow smoothly from one to the next? Are your paragraphs linked? Are the separate sections clearly identified but arranged in some logical order? Make sure the text reads effortlessly as a whole. If you find the text a little choppy, try evening it out with some transitional words or phrases such as:

- Words that lead to more on the same idea: *again, likewise, in addition, also, as well, furthermore, moreover, and*
- Words that lead to a different idea: *conversely, nevertheless, on the other hand, on the contrary, although, even though, but, yet, while, however, except*
- Words that lead to a result: *thus, therefore, consequently, as a result, because, since, as, so, inasmuch as*
- Words that lead to an example: *for example, to illustrate, if one looks at, as shown by*
- Words that refer to a previous time: *previously, before, prior to*
- Words that refer to the future: *next, then, later, afterward*
- Words that refer to the same time: *while, as, at the same time, during that time*
- Words that show sequence: *first/second/third, a/b/c, lastly, next, then, finally, after that, until*

Once your report is finished, proofread it to check for spelling and grammatical errors and for coherence.

3.1.7 Describe the Department policy on report taking

Report writing must conform with MPD policies and procedures. All reported offenses and many specified incidents require MPD officers to complete a report. These reports result from either calls-for-service or self-initiated responses. Any follow-up by the officer also must be documented. Initial reports must provide sufficient information by which an investigator or other MPD member can complete a supplementary report. Offense reports must describe offenses based upon the DCMR, DC, or US code. Any reports initiated during your tour of duty must be completed before you check off duty. You will not be allowed to check-off without having completed your reports. All reports must be accurate.

3.1.8 Distinguish between internal and external reports

It is important for officers to keep in mind what information become public. The public narrative portion of a report is available to everyone. Any law-enforcement sensitive information should be noted only in the internal narrative. In addition, arrest reports and juvenile delinquency reports (PD163/PD379s) are

not public documents. Personal information from reports are not open to the public and never listed in the public narrative. This is particularly true of identifying witness information.

Summary

By the end of this lesson, students should become adept at writing clear, concise, and chronological narratives. This lesson builds on the good notebook habits initially learned in prior lessons. A well-written narrative is the basis for many of the future situations that a recruit will encounter at the MPA. During your time at the academy, you will have many opportunities to practice writing both public and internal narratives.